

Dr. Saundarya Rajesh: A Trailblazer in Women's Careers and Inclusion



Dr Saundarya Rajesh
Managing Director
Avtar

"I decided to turn my struggle into a solution"

The year is 2001. A young woman computer science engineer, Sushmita, walks into an interview for the role of an RTG crane operator at the newly privatized Chennai Container Terminal. The job description clearly states that the role is meant for male mechanical engineers who can handle long hours and heavy physical work. Sushmita is neither. But she argues her case so well that she convinces every interviewer and becomes the first woman ever to be hired into the engineering department of the Chennai Container Terminal!

This determined, career-focused young woman was placed through a recruitment drive run by Avtar in 2001, a drive that successfully closed 224 positions even as India grappled with the dot-com bust. At the time, Avtar, now a leader in workplace-culture consulting, was barely a year old. In the 25 years since, Avtar has helped thousands of women like Sushmita step into meaningful careers in companies that genuinely value their talent. But how did this journey begin? That story is just as remarkable.

Avtar was founded by Dr. Saundarya Rajesh in 2000, and it began with her

own struggle. In the mid-1990s, when she tried to return to work after a career break for motherhood, she faced closed doors. Dr Saundarya says, "Organizations offered me lower pay simply because I had taken a career break." They ignored the stellar start she had made before her break in a coveted role at a top bank. But Dr Saundarya transformed that challenge into a movement that's opened doors for women across India!

"I realised my struggle wasn't mine alone. So many women were trying to build meaningful careers while nurturing their families, just like me. I decided to turn my struggle into a solution," she says. Dr. Saundarya Rajesh is the force behind the second-career movement in India and one of the world's most respected voices on inclusive workplaces and women's careers, with a PhD in the field. Her impact has been recognized with top honours: The UN Women Transforming India Award, the British Chevening Changemaker Award, and the President of India's 100 Women Achiever Award, celebrating her role as a true changemaker in the world of work. She has championed a simple idea: workplaces built on empathy and ethics enable both organizations and individuals to excel. And under her leadership, Avtar has sparked remarkable change. From conducting India's first recorded second-career program for women for a leading multinational bank in 2006 to running India's largest workplace-inclusion benchmarking studies – Best Companies for Women in India and the Most Inclusive Companies Index – in partnership with Seramount, Avtar's work has been pioneering, with many firsts to its credit.

In the last 25 years, Avtar has partnered with 800+ companies and enabled over 200,000 women through its career programs. And along the way, Avtar has delivered ~5,000 workshops that have shaped fairer workplaces. Its skilling initiatives (like DigiPivot – a prestigious digital marketing program run with Google, HUL, and ISB) have

helped hundreds of women grow with confidence.

Avtar's work covers every stage of a woman's career journey and is built on three strong pillars: Talent solutions, Workforce strategy and Career enablement services. This unique model of Avtar's, which integrates both B2B and B2C approaches, supports women and organizations alike, creating powerful impact at scale. In appreciation of its forward-thinking work, Avtar has been honoured with major global recognitions, including the Steward Leadership 25 by The Straits Times and INSEAD (2022). In 2025, the Times Group named Avtar India's Leading Women's Employment Organization.

"When I look back at our 25-year journey, my heart is full. We've touched so many lives, far more than we imagined. But it hasn't been smooth. In the early 2000s, no one wanted to talk about women's careers or inclusion. We have had several doors shut on us, and there have been times when we questioned whether our mission was too bold," says Dr Saundarya. But what kept the organization going was their deep belief in the power of women's financial independence. They fully understood that when a woman thrives, her children, her family, her workplace, and even the larger economy thrive with her. "I've been lucky to have a team at Avtar that truly believes in this purpose. Many of us are second-career women," adds Dr Saundarya.

Today, Avtar is poised for exponential growth, with plans to take its model to 24 cities across 12 states, influence 1,000 companies, and enable 500,000 women to rise by 2030. Dr Saundarya says, "We are pushing inclusion into sectors that have barely begun the journey, like manufacturing, real estate, and agriculture, so women can thrive in every corner of India's workforce. For me, the mission stays the same: help every woman build a strong career, and help every organization unlock stronger results by creating cultures that are both high-performing and humane."